

HACKXPLORE 2026

Pre-Event Intelligence Brief

Compiled: June 26, 2026 | Event: June 26-28, Karlsruhe | Source: OSINT (website + LinkedIn)

KEY FACTS

- 36-hour on-site hackathon at SteamWork by GoodSpaces, Karlsruhe
- Interdisciplinary teams of 4-5, approx. 4 teams per challenge
- Approx. 150 participants from approx. 400 applications -- SOLD OUT
- EUR 10,000 prize pool, backed by ZEISS Innovation Hub @ KIT
- Organized by NXTGN GmbH + MESH e.V., led by Tanita Martsch
- Under patronage of Ministry of Science, Research & Arts Baden-Wuerttemberg

Timeline

- Fri 6/26: Welcoming -> Challenges revealed -> Dinner -> Working Session
- Sat 6/27: Breakfast -> Working + Workshops -> Lunch -> Working + Workshops -> Dinner -> Working
- Sun 6/28: Breakfast -> Working -> Submission -> Lunch -> Pitches -> Award Ceremony

CHALLENGE SETTERS -- 6 Companies

ZEISS [Creative Sandbox]

Returning partner (2025 winner: FruitSense). Style: hardware + artifacts + "surprise us." Values: design, creativity, demo magic, visual impact, business innovation. Rep not confirmed. Ronald Smolka (Innovation Comms) attended 2025.

LBBW [Product / UX]

NEW for 2026 (EUR 330B+ assets). Challenge: "Use technology to engage a new generation in shaping long-term impact." Confirmed reps: Oliver Spagen (Head of Business Customers & Freelancers), Matthias Zartmann. Values: UX polish, Gen Z behavior understanding, green finance angle, product-thinking.

Hitachi Rail [Hard Engineering]

NEW for 2026. Challenge: "Process optimization for highly complex infrastructure projects." Confirmed rep: Abdullah Yildirim (Process, Tooling & Improvement Engineer), quoted in LOK Report (June 10, 2026). Values: algorithmic rigor, implementability, measurable improvement on real project data.

VEGA [HW/SW Integration]

Returning partner (2025 winner: Goblin Gang, radar-based system). Level & pressure measurement sensors. Values: bridge digital and physical, signal processing, industrial IoT, practical UX. Rep not confirmed for 2026.

Rentschler Biopharma [Digitization / OCR]

NEW for 2026. Challenge: "Where AI meets the analog world -- turning handwritten..." Heavily regulated GMP environment. Values: OCR accuracy, compliance awareness, practical digitization of paper processes. Likely rep: Gerrick Rodrigues (Global Head of IT, quoted in WBJournal Apr 2026).

Hirth Engines [Deep Engineering]

NEW for 2026. UAVs, light aircraft, ultralight aviation. No public challenge hint. Likely: engine telemetry, hybrid powertrain optimization, UAV mission planning, predictive maintenance. Values: telemetry processing, physics constraints, real-time data. Rep not confirmed. Peter Lietz (Head of Intl. BD) active externally.

JUDGES -- Not Publicly Listed

The /en/judges/ page on hackxplore.de does not exist (redirects to homepage). Google, DuckDuckGo, LinkedIn, and Instagram searches returned zero judge names. This is normal for HackXplore -- judges are revealed on-site on Day 3 (Sunday, June 28) before the pitch session.

Historical pattern: Senior engineers / innovation leads from challenge-setting companies + NXTGN/MESH board members. Industry practitioners, not academics. They value working demos and real solutions over slideware. 2025 had 5 company challenges, each judged by relevant company reps, plus an overall grand prize jury.

Likely Judges (inferred from confirmed attendance)

LBBW: Oliver Spagen / Matthias Zartmann -- Confirmed attending (HIGH confidence)
Hitachi Rail: Abdullah Yildirim -- Named rep, LOK Report featured (HIGH)
Rentschler: Gerrick Rodrigues -- Inferred from WBJournal quote (LOW)
NXTGN: Tanita Martsch -- Named HackXplore lead (MEDIUM)
ZEISS / VEGA / Hirth: No named reps found -- unknown (LOW)

COOPERATION PARTNERS -- 13 Ecosystem Partners

These support the event but do NOT set challenges. All confirmed via HackXplore LinkedIn showcase "Meet our Cooperation Partners 2026" post + website logo parsing.

- CyberForum -- Karlsruhe tech network
- GoodSpaces / SteamWork -- venue
- The Nerd Laend -- BW digital initiative
- brandl -- strategy consulting
- Pioniergarage -- student entrepreneurs from Karlsruhe
- KIT Gruenderschmiede -- KIT startup support
- karlsruhe.digital -- city digital platform
- Startup Verband (BW) -- startup advocacy
- Wissenschaftsbuero KA -- academia-city bridge
- Wirtschaftsfoerderung KA -- economic development
- Ritter Sport -- chocolate ("essential for the night")
- Hoepfner -- Karlsruhe brewery (since 1798)
- Festo -- industrial automation (returning from 2025)

STRATEGY SUMMARY

Target the challenge setter's values, not individual judge personalities:

ZEISS: Stunning demo, visual impact, creative surprise
LBBW: UX polish, Gen Z relevance, green/sustainable finance framing
Hitachi Rail: Algorithmic rigor, work with real data, measurable improvement
VEGA: Bridge physical sensor data with polished, practical software UX
Rentschler: OCR accuracy, GMP compliance awareness, practical digitization
Hirth Engines: Domain understanding, physics-aware optimization, telemetry

All information sourced from hackxplore.de, HackXplore LinkedIn showcase, karlsruhe.digital (June 2026), and LOK Report (June 10, 2026). Full dossier maintained.